

Raj Thackeray

Screen
PRESENCE

Move over all you TV studio politicians. If there is one that is made for TV, it is Raj Thackeray, the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena boss. His *raison d'être* has been to perform for TV crew recording his every move. Often referred to as a photocopy of his uncle Bal Keshav Thackeray, this "other Thackeray" has clawed his way to legitimacy, with some tacit support from the ruling Congress. Love him or hate him, but you cannot ignore him anymore. With his party winning 13 Assembly seats this year, the Xerox copy has finally got the stamp of approval from the electorate. Large sections of Maharashtra's population, the Marathi *manoos*, believe that he stands up for their rights. His fiery speeches and hooliganism have today helped Raj attain iconic status. His agenda may have been borrowed but it's mainstream now and has even forced his relatively timid cousin Uddhav to return to politics of hate. Regionalism and politics of hate may have kept him in the news undoubtedly, but it's certainly not enough to sustain his presence nationally.

by Malini Bhupta

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MAHADEO SEN



Madhu Koda

Dwindling
FORTUNES

It's queer. Madhu Koda—who shares his birthday, January 6, with A.R. Rahman—perhaps best reflects the theme that won the music maestro two Oscars. From a labourer in the depths of one of Jharkhand's iron ore mines, Koda went on to become not just the chief minister of the state but, if the many charges against him turn out to be true, one of the richest men in Jharkhand. Currently lodged in a Ranchi jail on charges of amassing disproportionate assets and committing money laundering worth Rs 2,000 crore, Koda leapt out of his humble origins to script a staggering success story by milking opportunities out of every crisis situation. His friends say Koda is not unlike many other politicians, who stashed away millions when opportunity knocked. They also say he is a simple man who was, perhaps, not clever enough to cover his tracks. Today, as he prepares for a long drawn legal battle, Koda is likely to stay under the spotlight in 2010 as well. Last month, his wife Geeta sacrificed 11 goats at a famous temple to propel Koda's career to fame—albeit not in the direction it is currently heading.

by Amitabh Srivastava